crossed by heavy equipment because of the impossibility of using bridges," recalled a participant in the operation. Other surprises followed. It turned out that the Cuban power stations were generating electricity with a frequency of 60 Hertz, while Soviet equipment was designed for one of 50 Hertz.[22]

News of problems with the chosen locations and the impossibility of hiding missiles and launchers even in the newly surveyed areas soon reached Moscow. Khrushchev would later blame problems involving the secret deployment of missiles on Biriuzov. "And so we sent Biriuzov there with an appropriate crew of staff members of rocket troops so that they could assess how best to deploy the rockets. They returned from there and reported to us that in their opinion the rocket deployment could be concealed. The poor qualities of those scouts became apparent: they naively believed that the palms would mask the disposition of the rockets."[23]

With the realization growing that it would be impossible to hide the missiles from the prying cameras of American U-2 spy planes, the Soviet military commanders decided to adjust their departure timetable for the Soviet missile troops. Instead of dispatching the medium- and intermediate-range missiles right away, the General Staff decided to send antiaircraft missiles ahead of the nuclear warheads and missiles capable of delivering them. The idea was to develop a capability to hit American U-2s before they could discover the deployment of the ballistic missiles. With such missiles in place, the deployment of R-12 and R-14 rockets could begin.

It turned out to be a brilliant move. The delivery of the antiaircraft missiles to Cuba indeed helped to keep secret the subsequent arrival of the nuclear warheads and R-12 missiles capable of carrying nuclear charges, but not in the way imagined by the Soviets. The Americans, alerted to but not greatly disturbed by the arrival of the antiaircraft missiles, assumed that the Soviet military buildup was limited to "defensive" missiles and missed the arrival of much more dangerous weapons. Khrushchev got lucky.[24]